WARHAMMER 40,000



ARKS OF OMEN

ABADDON

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A DARKENED PATH

The Farseers of the Aeldari possess the ability to scry all possible futures. It was a conclave of these seers, from multiple craftworlds, who reached out to Lord Inquisitor Coteaz of the Ordo Malleus. Coteaz was a powerful and respected daemon hunter, a level-headed pragmatist who heard out the strange xenos delegation in silence. Each of them had perceived a strand of fate, so they said, growing in potency and so drowned in darkness not one amongst them could perceive its end. They knew only that this darkened path had some connection to the Balefleets, and that it filled them with a presentiment of doom. Many of their people were already fighting to turn back or destroy the Balefleets, but they could not prevail alone. They needed Humanity's aid. Coteaz did not commit either way, and his strange visitors departed without the assurances they had sought, though – he pointed out archly – with their lives, which was more than some of his fellow Inquisitors might have allowed. Yet the moment he was alone, the Lord Inquisitor began readying orders to send to his best agents. He needed to know more of this business, and quickly.

Eventually, however, the loyalists' unity in faith saw them overcome the rival renegade warbands, who could not bring themselves to fight together even at the last.

After days of battle on the surface, Lord Gulthorg was forced to abandon command of the ground war and return along with many of his Sons of Rot to garrison their Ark against the Imperial warships. This was the moment the Alpha Legionnaires concealed within the traitor forces had waited for. Not trusting Gulthorg to fulfil Abaddon's orders, they issued their own carefully seeded commands through hijacked vox channels. At their false orders, an immense heretic attack wave abandoned their positions and broke against the walls of the Fortum Primus. Strategically the move was insane, leaving Gulthorg's ground forces horribly out of position. Yet the very madness of the assault caught the Fortum's defenders unawares and saw breaches blasted in their walls in a matter of hours. By the time loyalist ground forces converged to capitalise on the bizarre strategic misstep, the Alpha Legionnaires had plundered the trophy hall, stolen a shuttle and plunged through the warp portal that shimmered beneath the *Ogre*'s prow.

This was but one example of the bloody mayhem wrought by the Balefleets. On Aggamedes, the Ark *Bloodmaw* and its escort fleet began a months-long conflict against the maniples of forge world Graia that saw entire planets depopulated. Amidst the Rasputar Cluster the *Bane of Life*'s Balefleet plunged into an ongoing war between the Kin of the Kronus Hegemony and the Orks of Waaagh! Skullkrakka. The resultant carnage swiftly escalated to apocalyptic levels. Meanwhile, a hit-and-run conflict played out through the sprawling Serpessa Nebulae. Here, Flensemaster Thavak of the Night Lords found his Balefleet beset at every turn by the Asuryani of Craftworld Ulthwé and the Drukhari of the Kabal of the Iron Thorn, who sought to pick apart Thavak's forces one warband at a time.

Sainted Guilliman himself could take the field there. He still would not stop what is coming for them.'

'Of what do you speak, Warmaster? What power has been unleashed against Malakbael?'

The daemon sounded wary. *As well it might*, thought Abaddon. He felt a cruel smile twist his features as he spoke a single word, two syllables that had spelled the death of civilisations, the annihilation of worlds, the murder of entire species.

'Angron.'

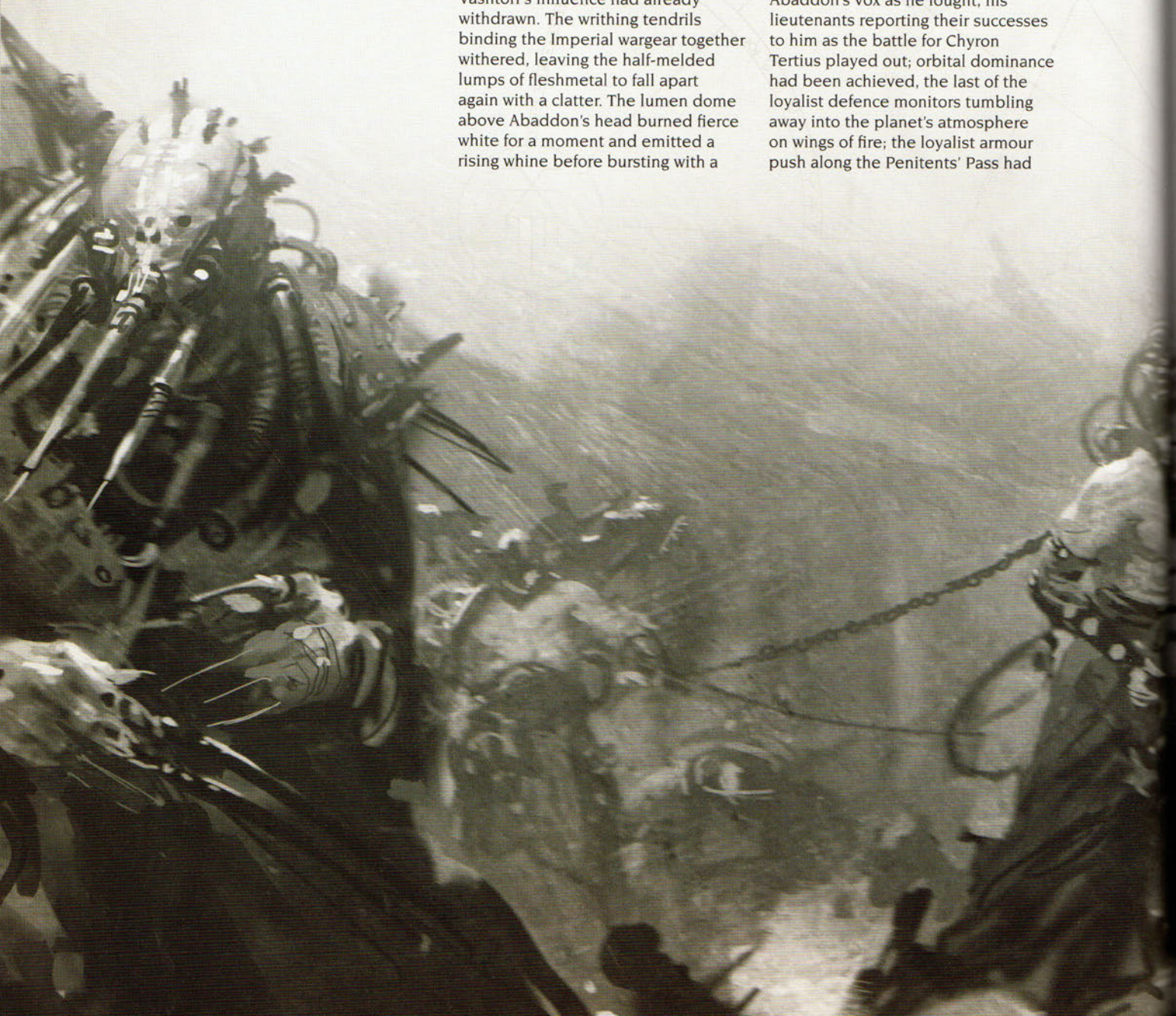
The word left his lips like a curse. It struck the air like a fist and left silence in its wake for several slow beats of Abaddon's twin hearts. When Vashtorr spoke again, he sounded calculating, intrigued.

'I will go. I will witness this for myself.'

'Do that, only do not trouble me again without good cause,' said Abaddon. 'I have my own battles to fight.'

He went to cut the vox channel, but Vashtorr's influence had already withdrawn. The writhing tendrils binding the Imperial wargear together withered, leaving the half-melded lumps of fleshmetal to fall apart again with a clatter. The lumen dome above Abaddon's head burned fierce white for a moment and emitted a rising whine before bursting with a bang. Ignoring the rain of shattered glass, Abaddon clenched the Talon of Horus, hefted Drach'nyen and strode out to join the butchery.

The fight for the Temple Ultima took almost another hour to conclude. Under Abaddon's leadership, Black Legion forces flowed in through the sundered Ascensor's Gate. Meanwhile, other lesser warbands prevented loyalist reinforcements from breaking through via Mount Sanctic, or fighting their way up the Devoted Stair from Saint Tathusa's Vale. Reports flickered through Abaddon's vox as he fought, his lieutenants reporting their successes to him as the battle for Chyron Tertius played out; orbital dominance had been achieved, the last of the loyalist defence monitors tumbling away into the planet's atmosphere on wings of fire; the loyalist armour push along the Penitents' Pass had



ARKS UNLEASHED

As the Balefleets of Warmaster Abaddon and Vashtorr the Arkifane tore their bloody paths across the galaxy, world after world was plunged into cataclysmic conflict. Traitors and heretics of every stripe did battle with defenders both Imperial and xenos – and occasionally even heretic – in the quest for the Key-fragments.

Where the coordinated – if lumbering – Indomitus Crusade fleets of the Imperium swept through entire sub-sectors at a time, the Arks of Omen and their Balefleets instead targeted individual systems and often specific worlds. The traitors brought concentrated military strength to bear against often-unsuspecting targets, leading to especially vicious battles that caused dreadful damage and slaughter.

Even when some factions across the galaxy began their fightback, each fresh conflict spawned by the Arks of Omen was focused and intense. Many took place aboard warring void ships, orbital defence platforms and even the Arks of Omen themselves. Funnelled into the claustrophobic confines of ill-lit corridors and chambers crowded with thrumming machinery, such fights came down to running gun battles and savage hand-to-hand combat. Each bulkhead door, choke point or valuable ship's system became a vital strategic objective for which rivers of blood were shed and bodies stacked high. Such was the nightmare war that the Arks of Omen brought to the galaxy.



Only rarely did Abaddon take to the field in person during the early stages of the Arks' onslaught. One such conflict was the battle for Dregglokke, during which a valiant force of Ultramarines led so determined a defence that they drew the personal ire of the Despoiler himself.



SET UP

You will no doubt have noticed by now that Boarding Action battles use unique terrain to lay out the claustrophobic corridors of the spacecraft where your fights will take place. This terrain is highly modular and can be clipped together in a large number of different configurations. If you are playing one of the Boarding Action missions presented in this book, the mission map will also show you where to set up the terrain features, along with the positions of each Hatchway.

Each piece of terrain on the mission map will be coded, allowing you to quickly identify which piece it corresponds to, and where that piece should be positioned on the game boards. You can find a key denoting the code for each piece on pages 68 and 69. We also recommend painting or writing the codes for each wall piece onto the underside of that piece – this will allow you to identify them quickly when setting up your game.

When placing these terrain pieces on the game board, the Wall sections line up with the lines between the Zones on the board and any Pillars line up with the smaller squares in the corner of each Zone, as shown below.

